to report the politics of this remarkable country where no two days (at times, no two hours!) are ever the same.

I am no soothsayer, even though journalists and editors like to believe they can give you a glimpse into the future. If you had asked me when I first met Narendra Modi in 1990 whether he'd be the fifteenth prime minister of India, my answer would have been firmly in the negative. If you ask me today whether Rahul can make a comeback, I'd again be hard-pressed to give an answer in the affirmative. No one can predict the future with any certainty, and especially not for India and Indian elections—this is the enduring fascination of this country.

Democracy is also the ultimate leveller. One of the great joys of anchoring live television shows on counting day is just to watch the crestfallen faces of mighty politicians who had taken the electorate for granted. I remember deriving almost sadistic pleasure on meeting Narasimha Rao after his loss in 1996. The prime minister who would treat television journalists with contempt had just got his comeuppance from the Indian voter—his pout was now even more pronounced.

The first election that I have a distinct memory of was the 1976 US presidential elections. As an eleven-year-old, I sat all day in the USIS building in Mumbai watching the results unfold in another continent. I had wanted Jimmy Carter to win that one over Gerald Ford—don't ask me why, maybe I just like peanuts! When Carter was declared the winner, I let off a scream of delight. That same feeling of exhilaration has accompanied every Indian election I have had the good fortune to report on since 1989. From Pehelwan Chacha in Varanasi to the fisherwoman in Sassoon Dock, it's that tingling excitement that only the festive spirit of an Indian election can bring to life. It's that great Indian story in all its rainbow colours that I have tried to capture in this book—the story of the 2014 elections, a mandate which has the potential of changing India and its politics forever.